

Designing Diegetic Prototypes in Interfuit: A Design Fiction Film on Near-Future Virtual Funerals in Japan

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Figure 1: Funeral venues attended by physical and virtual mourners: Examples of diegetic prototypes featured in the film *Interfuit*.

Abstract

This video introduces the diegetic prototypes from *Interfuit*, a design fiction film about near-future virtual funerals in Japan. These prototypes, including physical/virtual funeral venues, are fictional objects used in the story to show how people mourn, memorialize, and reconnect with the deceased in a society where virtual funerals are common. The film imagines a world where traditional funeral practices are freed from time and space limitations, with examples like attending funerals remotely or revisiting virtual venues years later. Our research through filmmaking highlights the potential for creative collaboration across fields to imagine alternative futures. The diegetic prototypes shown in this video are a key result of this research.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

Design Fiction, Film, Virtual Funerals, Diegetic Prototype, Research through Design

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1 Diegetic Prototypes in a Design Fiction Film

This 5-minute video introduces diegetic prototypes [1] featured in the design fiction film *Interfuit*, presented in a CHI 2025 Full Paper [4]. The diegetic prototypes are fictional artifacts conceptualized and depicted within the film. In this case, they include physical funeral venues (Figure 1), a virtual (online) funeral venue, and other elements, all set within the context of near-future virtual funerals in Japan. Below is a brief synopsis of the film:

Makoto, a bridal photographer, lost his father to an illness but struggled to process his emotions during the funeral. Two years later, he is given the opportunity to photograph the funeral of his friend's father. At the funeral venue (right in Figure 1), Makoto focuses on the deceased and is reminded of his own father's funeral. At that time, he had been unable to fully respect his father's passing due to the complex emotions he had toward him. As he prepares for another funeral, Makoto revisits his father's online virtual funeral venue. There, he uncovers hidden stories about his father, including messages and memories from those who had known him. Through this experience, Makoto gradually gains a newfound respect for his father. To mourn once more, he gazes at his father's portrait in the virtual venue, reflecting on the life and legacy he had previously struggled to understand.

The film envisions a near-future Japan where virtual funerals [4] are commonplace, exploring how people mourn, memorialize, and remember the deceased through diegetic prototypes. These prototypes, such as physical and virtual funeral venues, are woven into the narrative to illustrate these near-future possibilities. However, the film does not explain these prototypes or the hidden technologies behind them. Instead, it vividly depicts the characters' everyday moments related to memorial practices.

The designed diegetic prototypes transform funeral rites—traditionally constrained by time and place—into practices liberated from such boundaries through technology. For example, the story shows characters remotely attending a funeral and revisiting the virtual funeral venue two years later. These scenes are depicted not as extraordinary, but as harmoniously integrated with traditional rituals, enhancing the film's credibility as design fiction while maintaining its artistic quality.

Meanwhile, the restrained performances by the actors allow the audience to interpret virtual funerals in either a positive or negative light. The filmmakers intentionally avoided propagandistic depictions, instead aiming to inspire diverse opinions and insights. This understated approach encourages a broad range of interpretations, positioning the film as a “catalyst” for discussion and reflection beyond binary perspectives.

2 Research Significance of This Research through Filmmaking

Within the HCI design community, there is growing interest in producing design fiction films as both a prototyping method [2, 5] and a way to disseminate Research through Design (RtD) outcomes to wider audiences [3]. This film investigates how design fiction filmmaking can contribute to the exploration of future funerals.

The virtual funeral designs portrayed as diegetic prototypes [1] are realizable using current technologies, distinguishing them from the more speculative depictions typical in science fiction. Notably, none of these prototypes were pre-planned; instead, they emerged naturally through the filmmaking process. These prototypes provide a concrete visualization of near-future virtual funerals and a grounded simulated experience. Such realistic portrayals are expected to stimulate deeper reflections on funeral design within the HCI community and beyond.

The film was created through a collaboration between the first author, an expert in filmmaking who directed the production, and the second author, an expert in Research through Design (RtD) for mourning and memorialization, who oversaw the design of the diegetic prototypes [4]. Supported by the broader team, they inspired one another throughout the process, leading to the cohesive realization of both the film and the prototypes. This experience suggests that design fiction filmmaking can enhance not only the creative practices of designers but also the filmmaking processes of video creators.

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